

A Language of Threats

Chapter 2

The Kafka family residence was nothing short of lavish. There was not a single thing in the house that looked cheap. Yet, despite its grandeur, the system within the household remained terribly archaic, still governed by a rigid sense of caste and rank. Even the household staff wore uniforms with small pins fastened neatly to their pockets. The colour of each pin indicated their position.

A brown pin meant that they worked outside the Kafka residence, such as gardeners, gatekeepers, or those responsible for sweeping the grounds. A pale pink pin belonged to the domestic staff inside the house, ranging from first to third rank depending on how long they had worked there. White pins, however, were reserved for important personnel—personal assistants, business and financial advisers, and the like.

Those pins determined how deeply they were expected to bow and submit within the household. Brown and pale pink were considered the lowest castes, while white represented the middle rank and allowed its wearer to remain closer to the Kafka family, particularly Edward.

This was most apparent in the way Edward treated the people working in his household. He deliberately employed those who were helpless, discarded, or had nowhere else to go instead of hiring people who were genuinely skilled. He brought many of them into the household at a young age, trained them to work for him, and instilled doctrines that made them dependent upon him. That way, if they ever failed him, getting rid of them would be exceedingly easy.

The Kafka family themselves also had their own hierarchy. Edward stood at the very top, holding the greatest influence and authority. Matilda, Edward's wife, occupied the second position. Theodore, the family's eldest son, came third.

Kafka was the sole disruption to that hierarchy.

He was known as Edward's mistake, the disgrace of the family that had been carefully concealed. Born out of Edward's affair with another woman, Kafka had nevertheless been legally entered into the family register as though he were Matilda's son. Yet his position within the Kafka family remained a frequent subject of debate among the household staff.

As the second son, his authority should have been no greater than Matilda's or Theodore's. And yet, strangely enough, that very position meant that many of Edward's rules did not apply to him.

Kafka moved about with an astonishing amount of freedom compared to Theodore, who was constantly controlled by Matilda. At first, many of the staff assumed that Kafka would eventually be brought under Edward's control and made even more obedient than Theodore.

They were wrong.

Once he had grown into adulthood, the Kafka family's second son proved quite capable of defying Edward. Rather than continuing the family's politics and business within the Kafka corporation, he left the household and established a company of his own. He even entered partnerships with foreign countries, including America—the very country Edward despised.

That defiance left the staff uncertain. Some began to believe that Kafka might one day replace Edward, rather than Matilda or Theodore. Should anything happen to Edward,

Kafka might be the one trusted to carry on the family's business and preserve its reputation.

And so, after seeing him return following such a long absence, the staff became even more convinced that Edward favoured him.

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Kafka descended to the ground floor and glanced towards the dining room. At the far end of the long dining table sat Edward. Matilda sat on the opposite side of the table, with Theodore beside her. The silence that filled the room was nothing unusual. It was simply how things had always been in this house.

Kafka did not find it strange.

Before he had even reached his chair, Matilda spoke to him. “Finally, you've decided to come back. Do you have any idea how many problems we've had to deal with because of you?”

Kafka stopped for a brief moment. He said nothing. Instead, he calmly pulled out a chair positioned between the others, not too close to Edward, nor close to Matilda and Theodore. The middle.

He sat down with his shoulders relaxed, as though Matilda's words had barely reached him.

Almost immediately, the household staff stepped forward. A white napkin was carefully placed across Kafka's lap, followed by a glass of wine poured from The Mores Estate's Chardonnay, a luxurious wine from the Mores family, one Kafka particularly enjoyed.

It seemed Edward had deliberately ordered it for him. Kafka stared at the wine for a moment before letting out a slow, tired sigh.

Then he finally looked towards Matilda. "Isn't that your job? You're his wife, after all."

He picked up his knife and fork without waiting for anyone else. The blade pressed into the meat on his plate. Slice. He cut a piece, lifted it to his mouth, and ate.

Several members of the staff standing behind him stiffened. Kafka had started eating before Edward or Matilda, both older than him. It was a clear violation of the dining etiquette enforced throughout the house.

But that was Kafka.

He chewed slowly, completely unbothered by the uneasy glances behind him.

"Not eating?" he asked, glancing around the table. "We're all sitting here already. Are we only here to admire the plates?"

For a moment, nobody moved. Then Edward quietly picked up his knife and began cutting his meat. Matilda followed, and Theodore did the same.

Kafka's lips curled into a quiet laugh. "This house really hasn't changed. Still as backward as ever." He rested his elbow lightly against the table. "In this day and age, you still have to wait for Edward's permission before you can eat? I'm genuinely torn between calling you robots or the king's slaves."

He gave a small snort. "Though even calling you the king's slaves is rather amusing. We're not royalty. And if I may point out, the head of this family wasn't even born British, let alone a king."

His fingers tightened slightly around his fork. "Stop pretending we have a throne, a dynasty, a caste system, or whatever else. Just behave like normal people."

"This is dining etiquette!" Matilda snapped. "Wherever you are, you ought to have some!"

Her eyes immediately shifted towards Edward. "I told you. Your son is a rebellious, disgusting creature, just like his mother. Why are you still so stubborn about bringing him back? You should have left him to die out there!"

Kafka paused. His fork remained suspended halfway to his mouth. "Hm? Ah" Then one eyebrow lifted, "Legally, aren't you my mother? So does that make you disgusting as well?"

Matilda's expression darkened.

He picked up his food again and deliberately chewed with his mouth open, blatantly breaking yet another rule of the household.

"I thought you were all better than this. Apparently, you're exactly the same." He swallowed and leaned back slightly in his chair. "Can't you ever work together on something? If you want me dead out there, then at least plan it together. You are husband and wife, after all."

His eyes then shifted towards Edward. "I'd happily die out there rather than in this house. You know that."

Matilda gave him a thin, cruel smile. "Then die in the garden. Shall I have someone put a bullet through your head beside that old tree as well?"

Matilda was clearly referring to the way Kafka's biological mother had died, a detail whose truth had never been confirmed. The only person who knew what had truly happened was Edward. He had been the last person with her.

Matilda was not finished. "Oh, never mind. That garden will be visited rather frequently now. Best not to die there."

Kafka slowly lowered his fork. His fingers tightened around it until his knuckles turned pale.

"What do you mean?" His voice had changed.

The garden had long been abandoned, filled with moss-covered statues and ancient trees. Other than Kafka, no one ever entered it, not even out of curiosity. Most people deliberately stayed away because the place was said to be haunted, carrying an unsettling, almost supernatural atmosphere.

But to Kafka, the garden had always been different.

It was where he went to be alone. Where he could breathe. Where, for a little while, he could escape everything that weighed upon him.

Edward's gaze immediately hardened towards Matilda. "Enough. This is dinner." That was all he said.

Matilda's smirk disappeared. She looked irritated at being interrupted, but she knew better than to challenge Edward. Her lips pressed tightly together, and she fell silent.

Kafka watched the exchange carefully. Something was being hidden from him. His breathing grew heavier. His fingers slowly curled into a fist beneath the table.

"What the hell does that mean?!"

His chair scraped harshly against the floor as he suddenly stood. His fist clenched so tightly that his hand trembled.

“I told you not to touch that garden!” His voice rose, anger cutting through every word. “Bloody hell, you can touch anything else! You can ruin anything else in my life if that’s what you want, but not that garden! Are you actually deaf?!”

Edward released a long sigh. “The garden and our old house ... I sold them.”

Sold them.

The word seemed to echo inside Kafka's head. For several seconds, he simply stood there. His jaw tightened. His brows drew together. His lips parted as though he wanted to speak, but nothing came out.

Then his teeth clenched. His eyes began to sting, tears gathering despite his best efforts to hold them back. He was not crying because he was sad.

He was furious.

“I thought blocking access to my cards and selling my house was enough to make you happy,” he said, his voice shaking with restrained anger. “And now you’ve sold the one thing that actually meant something to me?”

He yanked the white napkin from his lap and threw it onto the dining table. The cloth landed beside his untouched wine glass. Kafka turned sharply, intending to leave. He barely took a step.

“Lower it.”

Only then did he realise Edward hadn't been speaking to him at all, but to the assistant standing behind him, a gun already trained on Kafka. The assistant's hand trembled almost imperceptibly around the weapon.

Edward raised one hand. The assistant immediately lowered the gun and handed it to him. Edward took the weapon. Then—

“Thup!” A muted shot.

The sound was almost swallowed by the suppressor. The assistant's body jerked. A dark stain spread rapidly across his shirt before his legs gave way beneath him. He collapsed heavily onto the floor. Blood pooled beneath his body.

Edward calmly lowered the gun and wiped its surface as though he had merely finished an ordinary task.

“You know that's what happens every time you break my rules.” His voice was soft. Almost gentle. The faint smile on his lips was horribly out of place beside the body bleeding on the floor.

Everyone in the house was accustomed to things like this. The staff immediately lowered their heads, their bodies stiff with fear, silently praying they would not be the next one.

Edward slowly raised the weapon again. This time, he pointed it towards one of the female staff members. “If you leave before dinner is finished, one by one, people will be end up on this floor tonight.”

“And you'll be the last one.”
